

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 11, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



After a City Council meeting on Wednesday, Ald. Nicole Lee, 11th, speaks to media on behalf of aldermen who are opposed to Mayor Brandon Johnson's budget and are hoping to put forth an alternate version. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Aldermen forge ahead with budget counterproposal

A sign members believe they don't need mayor to solve impasse on spending plan

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Aldermen officially threw their budget cards on the table Wednesday by introducing their own 2026 package to the City Council, the clearest sign yet they believe they don't need Mayor Brandon Johnson to solve the current impasse on next year's spending plan.

The high-stakes game of chicken between the freshman mayor and his council antagonists — including some of his own committee leaders — now moves from the dueling news conferences of the past weeks into the actual legislative process. In the increasingly likely event they can't reach a widely acceptable compromise, each side will try to build a proposal that can pass the council before the end of the year to avert a government shutdown.

That road remains murky, however, as cracks appeared in the aldermanic counterproposal's support. Still, the council members opposed to Johnson's \$16.6 billion budget officially brought forward their proposals, which broadly aligned with ideas in a letter signed by 26 aldermen and sent to the mayor last week.

The aldermen's budget does not include Johnson's controversial head tax plan, and hikes garbage collection fees, among other changes.

But in an indication of how controversial the idea is, they lowered the proposed new trash pickup charge to \$15 per household per month from the \$18 fee they initially discussed. Currently, the Chicago fee is \$9.50 per month for single-family homes.

The counterproposal also counts on the legalization and taxation of video gambling terminals in Chicago bars and restaurants.

Speaking to reporters after the council meeting, the mayor did not answer directly when asked whether that was a nonstarter for him, noting there's been "some consternation and some trepidation around" the issue.

Taxes on the gambling machines would generate \$48.4 million for the city, the aldermen predicted. Their projection is far higher than estimates by Johnson's administration earlier this year.

Their proposal would also tack a 10% tax onto short-term rentals like Airbnbs, to raise an estimated \$19 million.

In his afternoon news conference, Johnson said the budget "has to be" finalized by the end of this month.

"Look, I'm going to do everything that I can to avoid the chaos that, quite frankly

Turn to Council, Page 6

Ex-Summit police chief guilty of taking bribe

Kosmowski convicted on counts of conspiracy, bribery and obstruction of justice

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

More than six years after the FBI knocked on his door as part of a sprawling corruption investigation, former Summit police Chief John Kosmowski was convicted by a federal jury Wednesday of taking a bribe from a local bar owner in exchange for assisting with a liquor license transfer.

The jury of seven men and five women deliberated for about six hours beginning Tuesday before finding Kosmowski guilty on counts of conspiracy, bribery and obstruction of justice.

Dressed in a gray suit and striped tie, Kosmowski, 57, kept his eyes downcast at the defense table and showed no outward reaction as the verdict was read in U.S. District Judge Steven Seeger's courtroom.

According to the U.S. attorney's office, he faces up to 20 years in prison for the most serious charge of obstruction of justice. Bribery carries a 10-year maximum, while the conspiracy count calls for up to five years behind bars.

Seeger set a tentative sentencing date of March 27.

After the verdict, Kosmowski huddled in a conference room with relatives and his attorney for about half an hour before walking out of the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse alone. After spotting two news photographers, he sped up his pace and zigzagged several times north and south on Dearborn Street in an apparent attempt to elude them.

While the charges against Kosmowski were relatively low-level, the case was an offshoot of a larger corruption probe that netted indictments against then-state Sen. Martin Sandoval and a slew of



Kosmowski

Turn to Conviction, Page 4

‘The story of one more Venezuelan, one more Latino’

Aunt defends man arrested by ICE in Elgin standoff

By Laura Turbay and Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Roughly 2,400 miles from where her nephew faced an hourslong standoff with ICE agents in Elgin last Saturday, Genesis Adriana Gutierrez Morales' voice shook in Maracaibo, Venezuela, with sadness and rage at the words from authorities she said tarnished her nephew's name.

"I don't have the words to describe the frustration that you feel as family, of not being able to do anything, to be far away from him and not be able to help him," Morales, 35, said in Spanish in a phone interview with the Tribune. "And I'm angered by all the things they're saying about him that are false, angered that they are smearing his name when I know that does not represent him."

Morales describes Luis Jesus Acosta Gutierrez as an "incredibly hardworking" man with a huge heart. The Department of Homeland Security says he's a suspected member of the Venezuelan gang Tren de Aragua, an accusation the department has routinely leveled at Venezuelans detained during President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown.



Luis Jesus Acosta Gutierrez wraps himself in a blanket while barricading himself on a second-floor balcony of an apartment on Maple Lane on Dec. 6 in Elgin. The blanket was tossed up to him by a bystander when federal agents weren't watching. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

DHS said Acosta Gutierrez resisted arrest by intentionally ramming an officer's vehicle into a tree, an accusation his family and advocates deny.

Morales, who lives in Maracaibo and has helped care for Acosta Gutierrez, 31, since his mother died of cancer, said she was angered by the news headlines claiming Acosta Gutierrez is a suspected

Turn to Arrest, Page 8

MORE COVERAGE

- The federal government agrees to extend until April the temporary restraining order requiring improved conditions at the ICE holding facility in Broadview.
- Charges formally dismissed after grand jury refused to indict Laugh Factory manager accused of assaulting agents.

Stories in Chicagoland, Page 3

Illinois National Guard still federalized as order extended

Soldiers have spent most time confined to base, idle

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Three hundred Illinois National Guard troops remain under Republican President Donald Trump's control roughly a week after an initial 60-day federal activation order expired, continuing a clash over his unprecedented decision to seize authority over state soldiers who have spent almost their entire time confined to a base in northern Illinois and performing no operational missions.

Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker's office said Wednesday that the 60-day federalization order — issued Oct. 4 in conjunction with the Trump administration's Operation Midway Blitz deportation efforts — was earlier extended for at least another month, even though the soldiers have mostly remained at an Illinois Army National Guard training site in Marseilles and were never deployed for the White House's stated purpose of protecting federal officers and assets.

Turn to Guard, Page 4

US agencies at odds on boat strike survivors

Pentagon lawyers suggested putting survivors in El Salvador prison. The State Department rejected the idea. They were eventually repatriated. **Nation & World**

Fashion boutique Mango opens on Michigan Ave.

The location fills a large storefront on the Magnificent Mile and raises hopes more retailers will take another look at the area, which has struggled for years. **Business**



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Winding road paved with grit and hard work

How a season at Northwestern helped propel Pat Spencer from NCAA lacrosse star to a starter with the Golden State Warriors. **Chicago Sports**